



Wear improved

The immensely useful Android Device Manager is now available on Android Wear with the find my phone option. <http://dgit.in/DevWear>



The Cubi mini-PC

MSI launched the Cubi, which is an extremely tiny desktop PC with a host of useful features http://dgit.in/Cubi_Mini

Workshop

Creating and Optimizing gifs

Tired of not finding the appropriate meme at the right time? Learn to make your own GIF!

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If a picture speaks a thousand words, a GIF might just be the digital equivalent of penning *War And Peace*. Think of the countless times you've chuckled at a GIF on a thousand different subreddits. Now imagine an Internet where animations using GIFs wasn't supported. What a dull static internet that would be right? One thing's for sure, we would have fewer cats out there. Read on to find out why this 28 year old technology is still relevant till date and learn how to use it to your advantage.

The Graphics Interchange Format (better known by its acronym GIF) is a bitmap image format that was introduced by CompuServe in 1987 and has since come into widespread usage on the World Wide Web due to its wide support and portability.

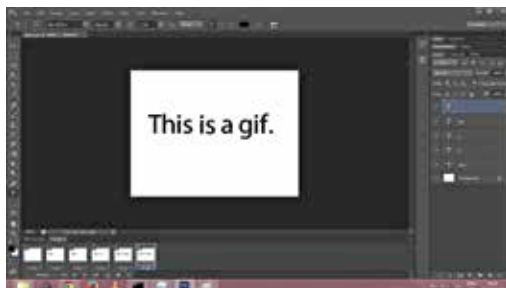
A GIF gets the point directly across without having to wait for too long and makes it the ideal format to use over a short video clip which takes time to buffer although playback options for GIFs remain very limited. The format is also quite commonly used in games for sprites which need a constant presence without increasing the CPU load and processing time.

Getting your hands dirty with Photoshop

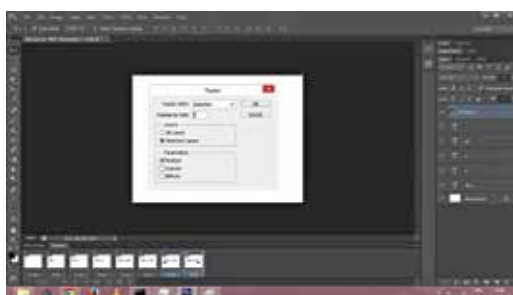
This simple tutorial combines the two most common animation techniques in Photo-

shop: Turning layers off and on, and using the Tween command to animate the movement of an object on a layer.

1. Find a suitable collection of images to make a GIF out of. Or formulate the idea for an animation.



Still Image Animation - Frames for each layer to be animated are made independently



Tween Settings - The Tween Settings Dialogue Box

2. 1-3 seconds is ideal for a GIF, 5 seconds is probably pushing it and anything above 10 seconds would be choppy and very hard to work with as the size would be very large.
3. Open Photoshop and set up layers.
4. Open Window > Timeline
5. Go to the dropdown for the Timeline panel and select the "Make Frames from Layers" option
6. For all the frames, enable visibility for

all the layers that are below the currently visible layer.

7. Drop Down Panel > Copy Frame. Drop Down Panel > Paste Frame > After Selection.
- 8a. Add a black rectangle to the new frame.
- 8b. Reposition the rectangle elsewhere on a new frame.
9. Drop Down Panel > Tween... (After selecting Frames 7 and 8).
10. The image provided shows the variety of options provided in the Tween Dialogue Box. It is recommended to play around with the options to get a better understanding.
11. Enable the visibility for the Background Layer along with the other layers for frames 8-12.
12. Add delays of 0.1-0.2 seconds on each frame.
13. You could even duplicate layers 7-13 and reverse the frames using the drop down panel.
14. Drop Down Panel > Optimise Animation...
15. File > Save for Web...
16. The image provided shows the options available in Photoshop while trying to save an animation in the GIF format. The GIF 128 Dithered Preset has been selected but feel free to play around with the controls such as the image size, quality, the colours in the Colour Table and Looping Options for repeating the animation once or forever.
17. 'Selective' is default for the colour reduction algorithm as shown in the image.
18. Preview the animation in a browser and optimise further if necessary. Optimisation is done by reducing the image size and the number of colours.